

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 45

Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1947, 1948, 1950

Coverage Date: 1945-1951

Place Coverage

northeast-central Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S): Additional Social Ties

Brotherhood Pacts. Beyond the range of the network of relationships which bound the people of one neighbourhood to those within their general vicinity, brotherhood pacts (*bulongwe*) once gave a limited safeguard to the traveller and provided for the exchange of goods between distant neighbourhoods. The new security and the new economic conditions have led to their decay, though inherited pacts are sometimes maintained at the present time and new-comers to an area may still create pacts with influential local leaders.

[438](#)
[Internal Trade](#)

[571](#)
[Social Relationships](#)
[And Groups](#)

Pacts apparently were most commonly created between men living in widely separated areas, where ordinarily no generalized pressure could be brought to bear to ensure life and property. A man who wished to trade in a distant area could create a pact with a local resident who then guaranteed his person and the safety of his property, intervening if necessary against his fellows. Apparently the pacts gave a man greater assurance of safety than was to be found in a claim on the hospitality of a fellow clansman or a clan joking-partner. The claim on such hospitality did not give protection against the attacks of others though it should prevent the host himself from taking action against his guest. Those of the same clan, or those who were clan joking-partners, ought not to enslave or hold one another in slavery, but they could turn a blind eye to encroachments upon the life or freedom of one who could only cite his membership in a clan as a claim upon them.

[438](#)
[Internal Trade](#)

[567](#)
[Slavery](#)

[571](#)
[Social Relationships](#)
[And Groups](#)

[618](#)
[Localized Kin Groups](#)

Today the Tonga feel that they have little to fear from contact with their fellow Tonga, and so the old pacts have been outmoded. But they attempt to utilize a similar device when they come in  [46](#) contact with aliens settled in their country. When they deal with these people, they feel that they move into a

[443](#)
[Retail Marketing](#)

[571](#)

foreign country where they are powerless unless represented by an inhabitant who is also a friend. Most Tonga are convinced that the shopkeepers in the townships cheat them by charging them higher prices than those paid by Indians or Europeans and by giving in return inferior goods. A man attempts to protect himself against this by choosing a particular shopkeeper to whom he refers as his special friend. He may visit all the shops in a township, but he makes his major purchases through his friend in the belief that he will be favoured above other Tonga. He expects his friend to greet him by name, to have time to listen to his comments, and to give him small gifts occasionally.

Social Relationships
And Groups

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)